UNIT 2

Rise of Extremism and Swadeshi Movement

Learning Objectives

- To understand the nature and significance of the Swadeshi Movement in Bengal
- To know the repressive measures of the government of British India
- To trace the events leading up to the Surat Split (in the Indian National Congress) in 1907
- To familiarise ourselves with revolutionary extremism in Bengal
- To acquaint ourselves with the Swadeshi Struggles in Tamil Nadu
- To examine the role played by V.O. Chidambaram, V.V. Subramaniam, Subramania Siva and Subramania Bharati

Introduction

By the last decade of the nineteenth century, there was conspicuous resentment against moderate politics within the Indian National Congress. This feeling of resentment eventually evolved into a new trend, referred to as the 'Extremist' trend. The extremist or what we may call radical or militant group was critical of the moderates for their cautious approach and the "mendicant policy" of appealing to the British by way of prayers and petitions. This form of militancy developed under the leadership of Bal Gangadhar Tilak in Maharashtra, Bipin Chandra Pal in Bengal and Lala Lajpat Rai in the Punjab. The primary reasons for the rise of this trend were: factionalism in the Congress, frustration with the moderate politics, anger against Lord Curzon for dividing Bengal.

The partition of Bengal in 1905 – a prime example of the British divide and rule policy – acted as the catalyst for the growth of anti-colonial swadeshi nationalism. The partition plan was first opposed by moderates but as the movement progressed, different techniques were improvised for the Swadeshi campaign. Swadeshi constructive programme included boycott of foreign goods and government-administered educational institutions. The Swadeshi movement (1905–1911) is the most important phase of the Indian National Movement in the pre-Gandhian era, as, during the course of the movement, the character of the Indian national movement changed significantly in terms of the stated objectives, methods and in its social base.



Swadeshi Movement

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